

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

When I think of focusing on scarcity or abundance, I think about a man from the Midwest named Mack who my team interviewed. If anyone could have naturally grown up focused on limitations, it'd be Mack. He was raised under constant financial pressure. In fact, his parents moved the family almost every year when he was young because they were always looking for cheaper rent. His father never graduated high school, and both his parents worked low-paying, blue-collar jobs. At the age of eight, Mack was responsible for getting himself up in the morning, going to school, and coming home—all on his own. Despite the constant moves and the holes in his school shoes, however, Mack never felt deprived. He instead chose to look for opportunities. That mind-set led him to graduate college and join the Army before starting a long career in the insurance industry. Throughout his career, Mack and his wife lived a modest, debt-free, and frugal life. They didn't get distracted by flashy cars and luxuries, instead opting to save as much as they could for as long as they could. He liked his job, but Mack had his eye on a goal: he wanted to retire early at age fifty-five.

Over the years, Mack was able to indulge in a few things, such as nice furniture and a private school education for their daughter and special-needs son. But through it all, he kept his eye on the prize. He worked and saved and worked and saved. When his company rolled out a 401(k) plan, he jumped in and maxed it out every year. He told us that he never planned to become a millionaire, but one day he opened his investing statement and saw a seven-figure balance staring back at him. He was blown away, mainly because he knew he and his wife wouldn't be a burden on their kids—and because he was happy to have a financial legacy to leave them. He realized he had changed his family tree.

Mack worked a little longer than he originally planned, retiring at age fifty-six with nearly \$3.8 million to live his dream retirement life of hunting, fishing, reading, cooking, and gardening. He has a peace and freedom that his parents could never have imagined; more importantly, his children have grown up looking for opportunities rather than accepting limitations. He isn't a celebrity, business wiz, lottery winner, or financial genius—but he *is* a millionaire—technically a multimillionaire. Not bad for someone with vivid memories of walking to school with holes in his shoes. Mack had the same opportunities as anyone else—if not less—and he took advantage of them. You can too.
